Extracts from the *Lawoe*'s logbook, engine room log and other reports were accessed, and sixteen witnesses were called. Captain Alex Flett did not appear as he was hospitalized in Colombo. The court dispensed with his appearance and found the documents presented and the evidence of J. Mathews, the first mate and S. Tucker, third officer sufficient. The primary task of the court of inquiry was to judge if the collision was 'accidental, and if so, avoidable or not'. Until this issue was settled, the court was not keen on appointing a nautical assessor, a requirement if the collision had been caused by incompetence or misconduct of the ship's officers. In all fairness, at least in this instance, the court was impartial—though all of them were Europeans and at least two of them, if not all had shown prejudiced behaviour earlier.

The following details emerged from the inquiry. On 24 July, the *Lawoe* occupied the inshore berth at Tuticorin port. On the other side, *Pandua*, *Nadia*, *Satara* and *Loodiana* were all heading to the shore. The sea was rough, and a strong wind blew from the west. At 6.28 p.m. the *Lawoe* began to heave anchor and, eleven minutes later, was going 'full speed'. Captain Mathews and Third Officer Tucker were on the bridge while the first officer was in the bows. The course took the *Lawoe* past the bows of the *Pandua*; but the strong wind pushed the *Lawoe* near her. As it cleared the *Pandua*'s bows, the *Lawoe* saw three cargo boats on port bow which had been cast off stern of the *Pandua*. At this point the captain ordered 'stop' and 'full steam astern'. But this could not prevent it from running into leading boat no. 19, drowning it. While the crew sprang, two men and a cook boy could not; their bodies were never found. The *Lawoe* began to lower a lifeboat but espying the BI's steam launch going to the wreck from the adjacent *Loodiana*, it proceeded on its course to Colombo.

On the question of whether the collision was avoidable, the court did not go by what Captain Honeywood, commander of the BI's *Pandua* said, on the grounds that, being the rival of SSNCo, 'his evidence might be expected to be against the captain of that company'. In the end the court decided that the *Lawoe*'s captain had no option but to adopt the course of action that he had chosen.